

Recognize it

Long green predator with pale oval spots on a darker body and rounded tail lobes.

Body	Cheek fully scaled, lower half of gill cover unscaled; five jaw pores per side.
Mouth/fins	Duckbill snout with backward teeth; dorsal and anal fins far back.
Confusion	Musky usually has dark marks on light body, pointed tail, and six to nine jaw pores.

Lake role

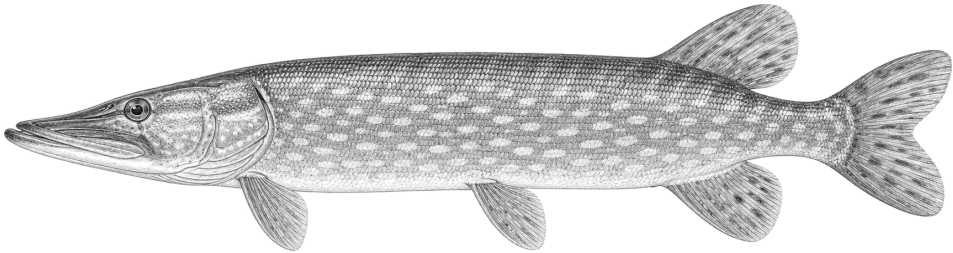
Where it belongs

Weed edges, points, current seams, and cooler deep structure in summer.

Food and season

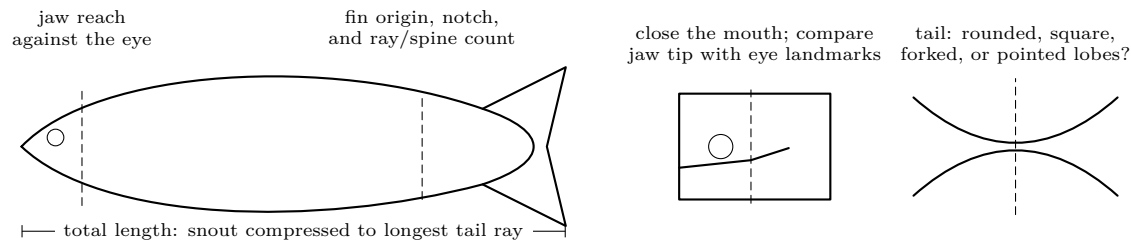
Fish predator; early shallow vegetation, then follows prey and tolerable temperature.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Read the fish before naming it



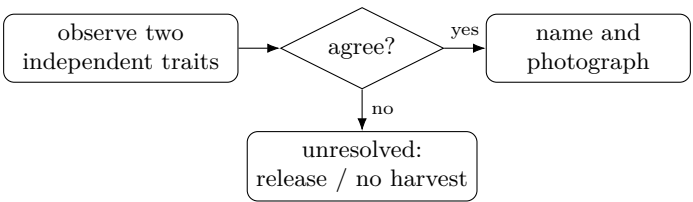
- 1. **Silhouette first.** Inspect the tail for rounded lobes and the long duckbill profile.
- 2. **Hard structure second.** Confirm five jaw pores per side and a fully scaled cheek with the lower gill cover partly bare.
- 3. **Markings last.** Use pale oval spots on a dark field only after the structural checks.

Intermediate questions

Before looking at the species name, answer aloud: *Where does the closed jaw end? Are dorsal sections joined or separate? What is the tail-lobe shape? Which mark is structural enough to survive poor light?* If two answers conflict, record “unresolved” and do not force the identification.

Confusion-pair gate

Candidate	Northern Pike
Nearest alternative	Musky usually has dark marks on light body, pointed tail, and six to nine jaw pores.
Required gate	Pike requires rounded tail lobes plus five pores or the pike cheek/gill-cover scale pattern.
Independent check	Photograph the tail and underside while the fish remains supported; do not probe gills or teeth.



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test spring vegetation and later the deep, cool outside weed edge rather than hot shallows.
North	Test weed walls, narrows, and inlet/outlet current with open water beside cover.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Field evidence log

Date/time	Water + station	Depth/temp	Two observed traits	Habitat, lure, result
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Evidence threshold. One sighting is an observation, not an abundance claim. Repeat the same identification gate on another fish, retain a clear lateral photograph when lawful and safe, and note failed searches as carefully as catches. Record weed edge, temperature, and landing time; warm-water captures change the handling decision.

Presentations

1. **Spoon or swimbait.** Run parallel to the edge; add pauses while retaining contact above vegetation.
2. **Quick-strike live bait.** Where lawful, use a leader and immediate-set two-hook rig to prevent deep hooking.
3. **Stop rule.** If water is very warm or the fish cannot be landed promptly, target another species.

On-water verification
After the first response, ask: <i>Did the fish, depth, cover, and bite match the prediction?</i> Repeat once. If the second result disagrees, return to search mode rather than explaining away the evidence.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME
Use leader, net, long pliers, and cutters. Keep fingers out of mouth and gills; support fish horizontally.

Harvest decision · 2026–27

Water-specific rule	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 26-in minimum; daily bag 2 on both lakes.
Kitchen choice	A legal lower-end fish is preferable to a large breeder; use the five-piece Y-bone method.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use
Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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